



THE VEGAN MASALA GUIDE

Authentic Indian Vegan Breads

Roti, naan, poori and regional breads

Culture • flour • ovens • hand-forming • home technique

A practical, illustrated introduction for curious home cooks

VEGAN-MASALA.COM

AT THE INDIAN TABLE

Why bread matters

An everyday food, an edible utensil and a carrier of flavour



Fresh roti moves straight from the tawa to the table

THE EVERYDAY LOGIC

For many wheat-eating households, a basic roti begins with atta, water and heat. That economy matters: it turns an inexpensive grain into a fresh, filling companion for dal, sabzi and curry.

BREAD AS CUTLERY

A piece of roti can be torn, folded into a small pocket and used to gather a bite of sabzi or thicker dal. It is both food and utensil – tactile, efficient and designed for the meal around it.

Eating practices vary. Many people use the right hand; others use cutlery, or both. Clean hands and respect for the host matter more than performing a single 'correct' ritual.

A small cultural lens

The pleasure is rhythmic: tear, fold, scoop, eat. Bread is often cooked in batches but served one by one, which means the cook's work and the diners' meal overlap. A cloth-lined dabba or basket keeps each roti soft, while the next one balloons on the tawa.

That sequence is one reason fresh bread feels hospitable. It is not just beside the food; it changes how the meal is handled, shared and tasted.

One country, many breads

Think in families of grain and technique, not a single national loaf

ROTI & PHULKA

NORTH AND CENTRAL INDIA

Whole-wheat atta; unleavened. Cooked on a tawa, then sometimes puffed over flame.

NAAN & KULCHA

TANDOOR TRADITIONS

Usually refined wheat flour and leavening. Restaurant versions may contain dairy or egg – always ask.

PARATHA & PAROTTA

LAYERED AND GRIDDLED

Folded or laminated dough gives flaky layers; fillings range from potato to radish or fenugreek.

POORI & BHATURA

FRIED BREADS

Poori is unleavened and whole-wheat; bhatura is leavened and often made with refined flour.

BHAKRI, ROTLA, MAKKI ROTI

MILLET AND MAIZE BELTS

Jowar, bajra or maize create earthy, often gluten-free breads that need patient hand-forming.

APPAM & NEER DOSA

SOUTHERN AND COASTAL TRADITIONS

Rice-based batter breads show why 'Indian bread' is wider than wheat and wider than the tandoor.

Cultural reference: Kashmir's kandur

In Kashmir, neighbourhood kandurs traditionally bake breads for daily life in clay ovens. The bakery is both food infrastructure and a social place – a reminder that Indian bread-making can belong to a community, not only a domestic kitchen.

four foundations

Good bread starts before the heat



Atta, water, rest and repetition

1 CHOOSE THE FLOUR

Chakki atta is finely milled whole wheat and behaves differently from coarse Western wholemeal flour. For soft roti, use chapati atta when you can.

Refined maida gives naan and kulcha their softer, stretchier structure. Millet and maize doughs contain no gluten, so they are patted or pressed rather than stretched.

2 HYDRATE GRADUALLY

Add water in stages. The dough should feel soft and supple, not wet. Flour age, brand and room humidity change how much water it absorbs.

A rigid formula is less useful than learning the feel.

3 REST THE DOUGH

A 20-30 minute rest lets flour hydrate and makes atta dough easier to roll. Keep it covered so the surface does not dry.

For naan, fermentation or chemical leavening builds tenderness and bubbles.

4 MATCH THE HEAT

Roti needs a properly preheated dry tawa. Too cool and it dries before it colours; too hot and the outside scorches before the inside sets.

Poori needs steady oil heat; naan needs fierce top heat or a tandoor wall.

THE VEGAN CHECK

- Atta roti is commonly vegan: flour and water.
- Ask about ghee brushed on top.
- Naan dough may contain yoghurt, milk or egg.
- Use unsweetened plant yoghurt and neutral oil at home.

TECHNIQUE ONE

Chapati: roll, turn, puff

The everyday bread that teaches dough feel and heat control



Roundness comes from even pressure and frequent quarter-turns

1

MIX Combine 250 g chapati atta with about 160-175 ml warm water, added gradually. Knead 7-10 minutes until smooth.

2

REST Cover and rest 20-30 minutes. Divide into 8 equal balls; keep them covered.

3

ROLL Flatten, dust lightly and roll from the centre. Turn the disc often rather than forcing the edges.

4

TAWA Cook on a hot dry tawa until small bubbles form. Flip; cook until brown spots appear.

5

PUFF Flip once more and press gently at the edges, or finish briefly over a gas flame with tongs if you are confident.

6

HOLD Stack in a clean cloth. Steam trapped between warm rotis keeps them flexible.

SAFETY Keep sleeves, cloths and loose hair away from an open gas flame. Use tongs, never fingers.

TECHNIQUE TWO

Inside the tandoor

Why oven shape, clay and fierce radiant heat change the bread



A baker uses a padded gaddi to place naan against the hot clay wall

HOW IT WORKS

A tandoor is a deep cylindrical clay oven. Fuel burns below; the hot wall cooks one side of the bread by contact while radiant heat colours and blisters the other.

WHY NAAN IS DIFFERENT

A hydrated, leavened dough stretches into an oval and clings to the oven wall. The intense heat creates a tender centre, charred bubbles and a flavour a low oven cannot exactly copy.

Naan is not automatically vegan: check yoghurt, milk, egg and butter.

A safer home approximation

Preheat a cast-iron pan until very hot. Lay on the shaped naan; when bubbles rise and the base chars, move the pan beneath a fierce overhead grill to blister the top. Use an oven-safe pan and protect the handle.

Do not build or improvise a tandoor indoors. A true tandoor needs specialist installation, ventilation and fire-safe operation.

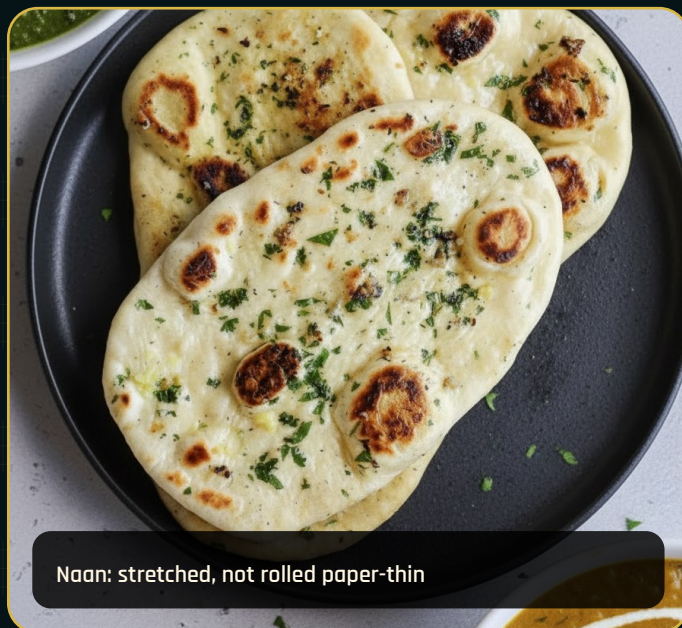
TECHNIQUE THREE

Beyond the rolling pin

Different grains demand different hands



Poori: rolled evenly, then fried to puff



Naan: stretched, not rolled paper-thin

PAT & TURN

Bajra, jowar and maize doughs have little or no gluten. Pat them between damp palms or on a lined surface, repairing cracks as you turn.

Warm water often improves cohesion; work while the dough is fresh.

FOLD & LAYER

Paratha gets its flake from fat and folds. Roll, brush lightly with oil, fold or coil, rest, then roll again without crushing every layer.

Cook with a little oil until crisp and mottled.

FRY & PUFF

Poori puffs when evenly rolled dough enters sufficiently hot oil and steam expands inside. Slide it away from you, press gently with a slotted spoon, turn once and drain.

Never leave hot oil unattended.

STRETCH & SLAP

Naan is left thicker than roti and stretched into a teardrop or oval. In a tandoor it is slapped onto the wall with a padded tool; at home, lay it smoothly into a hot pan.

Keep toppings sparse so they do not burn.

Ten breads worth knowing

Names overlap across languages and regions; technique is the useful compass

BREAD	FLOUR	HEAT	WHAT TO EXPECT
Chapati / roti	Atta	Tawa	Soft, everyday, unleavened
Phulka	Atta	Tawa + flame	Thin roti finished until fully puffed
Tandoori roti	Atta	Tandoor	Chewier, smoky, blistered
Naan	Maida	Tandoor	Leavened, tender; check dairy/egg
Kulcha	Maida	Tandoor / oven	Leavened or stuffed
Paratha	Atta	Tawa + oil	Layered or stuffed, crisp-edged
Poori	Atta	Deep-fried	Small, crisp-tender and puffed
Bhatura	Maida	Deep-fried	Leavened, large and pillowy
Bhakri / rotla	Millet / sorghum	Tawa	Rustic, hand-patted, earthy
Makki di roti	Maize	Tawa	Punjabi winter bread; fragile dough

A pairing to remember

Punjab's makki di roti with sarson da saag links a maize bread with winter mustard greens. It is a seasonal partnership, not just a generic 'bread and curry' combination.

four breads to practise



Chapati

The best first lesson in hydration, even rolling and tawa heat.

[Open the full recipe](#)



Vegan garlic naan

Soft leavened bread with garlic, cooked with a hot-pan method.

[Open the full recipe](#)



Vegan peshwari naan

A filled, gently sweet naan for practising sealed edges.

[Open the full recipe](#)



Poori

A lesson in even thickness, oil temperature and steam.

[Open the full recipe](#)

What went wrong?

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	NEXT TIME
Roti is tough	Dough too firm; too much bench flour; cooked too long	Add water gradually, roll lightly and use a hotter tawa for a shorter cook.
Roti will not puff	Uneven thickness; cool tawa; edge did not seal	Roll evenly, preheat fully and press around the rim after the second flip.
Roti dries in minutes	Overcooked or left uncovered	Cook just until spotted, then stack immediately in a clean cloth.
Naan is dense	Under-proofed; dough too dry; heat too gentle	Allow visible fermentation, keep dough soft and use the fiercest safe top heat.
Naan tastes cakey	Too much raising agent	Measure carefully and favour fermentation for flavour.
Millet bread cracks	Dough cooled or lacks moisture	Use warm water, shape promptly and repair edges with damp fingers.
Poori stays flat	Oil too cool or disc uneven	Test with a scrap: it should rise promptly. Roll to an even 2-3 mm.
Poori is oily	Oil too cool; bread sat in oil	Raise heat moderately, fry one at a time and drain as soon as both sides set.

A first imperfect roti is useful: it tells you whether the next needs more water, more heat or a lighter hand.

OPTIONAL TOOLKIT

Buy less. Choose well.

Useful ingredients and equipment – with transparent affiliate links



A broad, low-sided tawa makes turning and lifting bread easier

CAST-IRON TAWA

The one specialist tool most likely to improve roti, paratha and home-style naan. Choose a broad, low-sided pan and preheat it properly.

[View the 28 cm cast-iron tawa](#)

CHAKLA & BELAN

A compact rolling board and slim Indian-style pin make frequent turning easier than a very heavy Western rolling pin.

[Compare chakla-and-belan sets](#)

CHAPATI ATTA

Finely milled whole-wheat chapati flour usually gives softer, more flexible roti than coarse wholemeal bread flour.

[Compare chapati atta](#)

METAL TONGS

Long, precise tongs keep fingers away from hot pans and open flames. Avoid silicone tips near direct flame.

[Compare stainless-steel tongs](#)

AFFILIATE DISCLOSURE We may earn a commission from qualifying purchases, at no extra cost to you.

Seven days to better bread

Repeat one movement at a time instead of chasing perfection

DAY 1

Feel

Mix atta dough. Notice how it changes from rough to supple as you knead and rest it.

DAY 2

Roll

Roll eight dry practice discs. Focus on even thickness and quarter-turns, not perfect circles.

DAY 3

Heat

Cook chapatis and adjust the tawa between batches. Record which heat gives spots without dryness.

DAY 4

Puff

Try phulka. Look for even rolling and a sealed rim rather than pressing hard.

DAY 5

Lager

Make a simple oil-layered paratha and compare its texture with chapati.

DAY 6

Leaven

Make vegan garlic naan with plant yoghurt. Use cast iron plus an overhead grill.

DAY 7

Share

Serve one bread fresh with dal and sabzi. Practise tearing and folding a bite at the table.

The goal is not a perfect circle. The goal is bread that is tender, properly cooked and served while it is alive with heat.

Sources, language & next steps

A short reading list for culture and technique

USEFUL WORDS

- Atta – whole-wheat flour used for roti
- Tawa / tava – flat or gently curved griddle
- Belan – rolling pin
- Chakla – rolling board
- Gaddi – padded tool for placing bread in a tandoor
- Kandur – traditional Kashmiri baker / bakery context
- Phulka – roti finished so it balloons

READ WITH NUANCE

India's bread traditions cross languages, religions, regions and borders. Names and spellings vary, and household technique is often more authoritative than a rigid definition.

This guide uses 'vegan' to flag modern ingredient checks. Many everyday breads have always been plant-based, while restaurant finishes and enriched doughs may not be.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

1. [Traditional wheat flatbreads of India – scientific review](#)
2. [Recent advances in chapatti technology – open research review](#)
3. [Kandurs of Srinagar: breadmaking in Kashmir Valley – Sahapedia](#)
4. [Indian Food Heritage – National Council for Hotel Management](#)
5. [Vegan Masala recipes and cooking guides](#)

Cook the next bread

Begin with chapati, then let the grain and heat lead you outward: a flaky paratha, a blistered vegan naan, a hand-patted millet bhakri or a festive poori.

Explore all Vegan Masala recipes

Share what you make: @veganmasalaonline